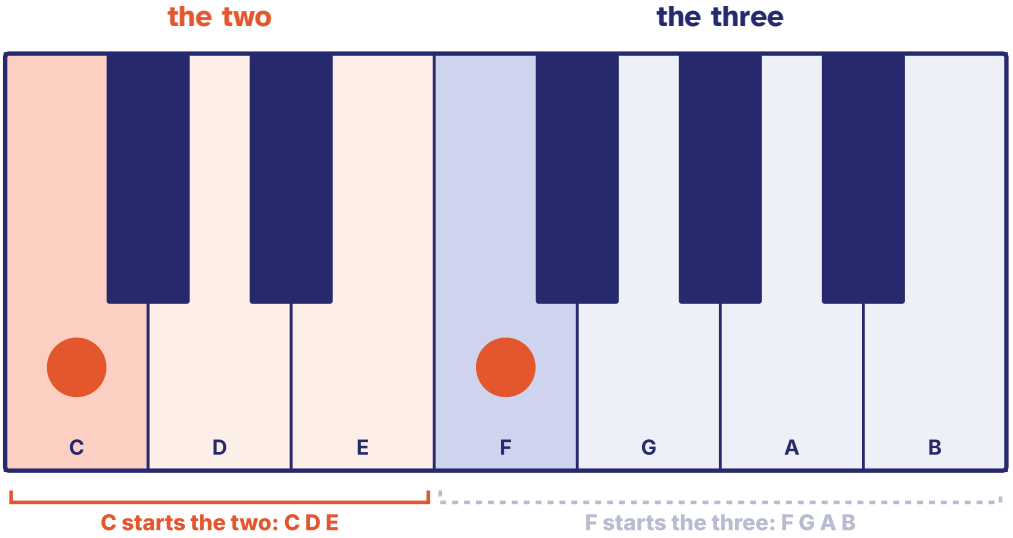
PART I · PITCH · 1

The keyboard

Left is **low**, right is **high**. The black keys come in groups of **two** and **three**. Each group has a first white key, just to its left: **C** for the two, **F** for the three. Find the group, find its first key, then walk on.

THE SECRET

Two black keys: start on C. Three black keys: start on F. Then walk on.



Two black keys: C D E · three black keys: F G A B

THE RULE

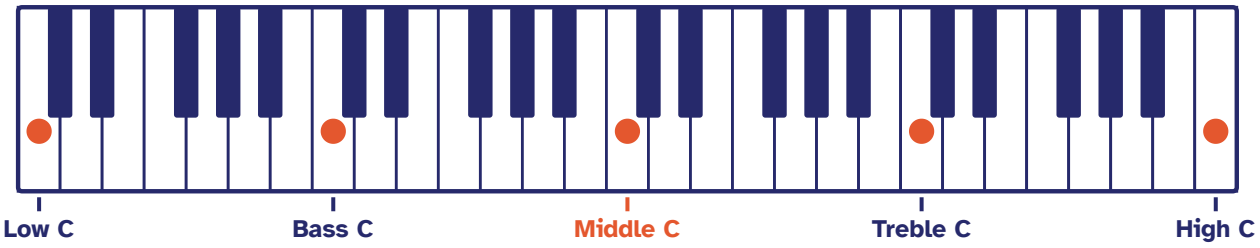
Find the group, then its first key. Looking for D or E? Find two black keys and start on C. Looking for G, A or B? Find three black keys and start on F. You never have to count from far away.

Seven letters, two families

The white keys use seven letters, **A B C D E F G**, then start again, like the days of the week. They live in two families: **C D E** round the two black keys, **F G A B** round the three.

The five Cs have names

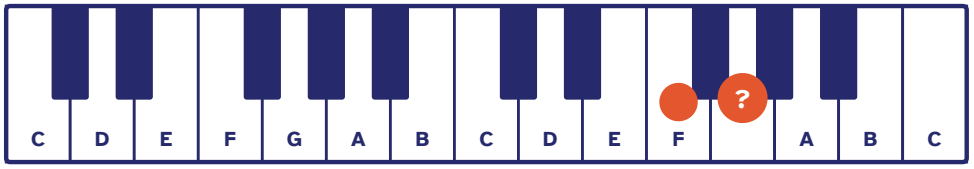
The C nearest the middle is **Middle C**. The Cs either side are **Bass C** and **Treble C**; further out, **Low C** and **High C**. From one C to the next is an **octave**: C D E F G A B C, eight notes, both Cs included.



PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Find G

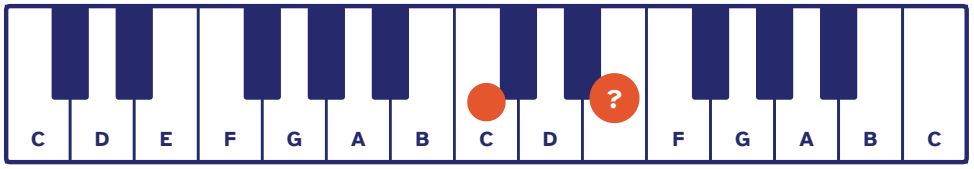


1. **Which family?** G is in F G A B: look for **three** black keys.
2. **Find its first key:** F, just left of the three (the red dot).
3. **Walk on one key.** That is the **?**.

The **?** is **G**: the key after F. No need to start from C and count five.

EXAMPLE 2

Find E



1. **Which family?** E is in C D E: look for **two** black keys.
2. **Find its first key:** C, just left of the two (the red dot).
3. **Walk on:** C, D … the third key is the **?**.

The **?** is **E**: the last of the C D E family, just right of the two black keys.

EXAMPLE 3

Find B



1. **Which family?** B is in F G A B: three black keys.
2. **Start on F** (the red dot).
3. **Walk on:** F, G, A … the last key of the family is the **?**.

The **?** is **B**: the last of F G A B, just right of the three black keys.

GAME

Which family?

1	2	3	4	5	6
D	A	F	E	B	G

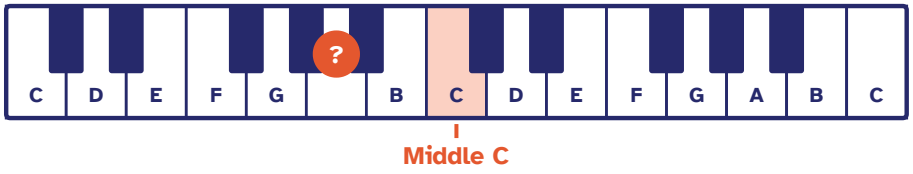
Does each white key live with the **two** black keys (start on C) or the **three** (start on F)?

Answer: 1 two · 2 three · 3 three (the first) · 4 two (the last) · 5 three (the last) · 6 three.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 4

Find the A below Middle C

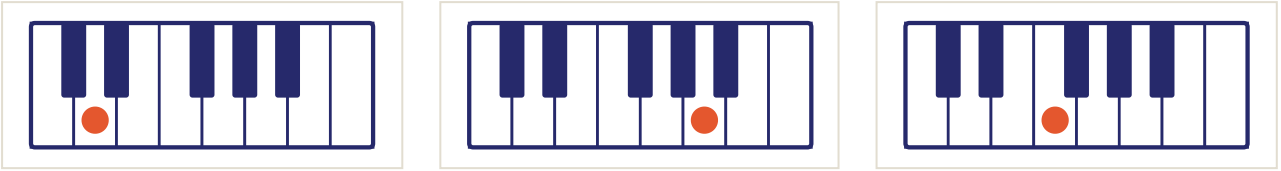


1. **Which family?** A is in F G A B.
2. **From Middle C, look left** for the nearest three black keys, and start on their F.
3. **Walk on:** F, G … the third key is the **?**.

The **?** is **A**: F, G, A. Find the family first, and every key is at most three steps away.

GAME

Name the key



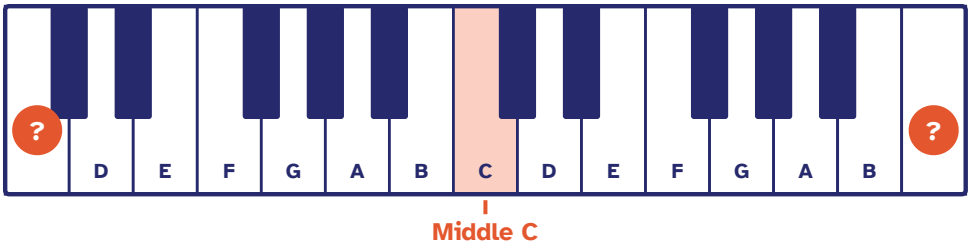
1 2 3

Find the group, then its first key, then walk on. Name each red key.

Answer: 1 D (C, then D) · 2 A (F, G, A) · 3 F (the first of the three).

EXAMPLE 5

Find Bass C and Treble C



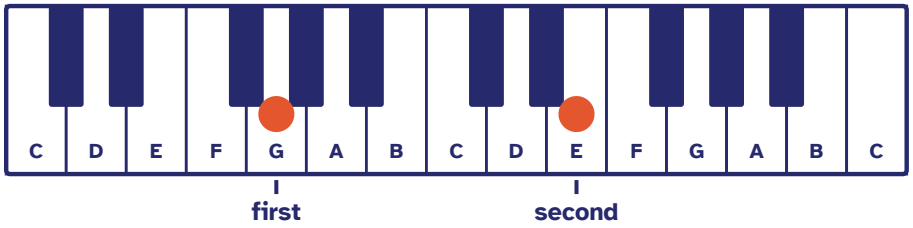
1. **Start on Middle C.**
2. **Walk left** to the next pair of black keys. The C just left of it is one **?**.
3. **Walk right** the same way, to the next pair: the other **?**.

Left **?**: **Bass C**. Right **?**: **Treble C**. Each is one octave, eight notes, from Middle C.

PART I · PITCH · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 6

Higher or lower?



1. **Find the two red keys.**
2. **Which one is further right?**
3. **Right means higher:** play both and listen.

The second note is **higher**: it is to the right. Left is always lower, right always higher.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

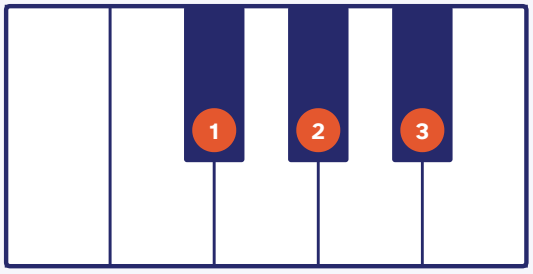


Play every C, then every F.

Bottom to top, saying the names: Low C, Bass C, Middle C, Treble C, High C. Then every F: left of the three.

YOU KNOW THIS

Hot Cross Buns, on three black keys



Play the group of three black keys from the top: **3 2 1**, 3 2 1, then 1 1 1 1, 2 2 2 2, 3 2 1. You just played a whole tune without one white key.

Try it. Find another group of three, higher up, and play it again there.

THINK OF IT The black keys are bumps you can feel in the dark. Close your eyes and slide your hand along: two bumps, and the key to their left is C; three bumps, and the key to their left is F.

TRAP

- × Counting every key from C: find the nearest group and start from its C or F.
- × Mixing up the families: C is left of the **two** black keys, F left of the **three**.

SEE ALSO

The staff and the clefs p. 26 · The staff and the keyboard p. 32

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 1 · Online: Library › Keyboard